

**Confirmation of False-Flag Shooting of Maidan Activists in Khmelnytskyi by Ukrainian
Trial Verdict and Investigations**

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Abstract

This study analyzes revelations and findings of the Ukrainian trial verdict and other court decisions concerning killings of two Maidan protesters and wounding of 10 others in Khmelnytskyi in Ukraine on February 19, 2014. This case of political violence is closely linked to the Maidan massacre, which led to the overthrow of the Ukrainian government and ultimately to the war in Donbas, Russian military interventions in Crimea and Donbas, the Russian annexation of Crimea and conflicts of Russia with Ukraine and the West that Russia escalated by launching the illegal invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022. This paper analyzes the content of the text of the verdict, which was issued by the Khmelnytskyi court in March 2025 following a several-year long closed trial, and other court decisions concerning this case from the official database of court decisions in Ukraine. This verdict and government investigations de facto confirmed, based on such evidence as videos, forensic ballistic and medical examinations, on-site investigative experiments, and witness testimonies, that the Maidan activists in Khmelnytskyi were shot not by the SBU officers but by far-right Maidan activists. The study compares this to findings of scholarly studies and narratives propagated by governments and the media and discusses implications.

Previous Studies and the Research Question

This paper analyzes revelations and findings of the declassified Ukrainian trial verdict in 2025 and other court decisions concerning killings of two Maidan protesters and wounding of 10 others in the city of Khmelnytskyi in Ukraine on February 19, 2014 during Euromaidan. The research question is what the verdict reveals about which party of the Maidan conflict perpetrated this case of political violence, which is closely linked to the Maidan massacre in Kyiv on February 18-20, 2014.

The massacre of the protesters and the police during Euromaidan in Ukraine was a crucial case of political violence in Ukraine and the world. (See Katchanovski, 2016a, 2020, 2021, 2023a, 2023b, 2024; 2025a, 2025b; Kudelia, 2018). This mass killing resulted in the overthrow of the Viktor Yanukovich government and ultimately led or contributed to the annexation of Crimea by Russia, a civil war and Russian military interventions in Donbas, and conflicts between Ukraine and Russia and the West and Russia. (Black and Johns, 2016; Katchanovski, 2015, 2016b, 2017, 2025b; Hahn, 2018; Sakwa, 2015). Russia escalated these conflicts on February 24, 2022, with the illegal invasion and the war with Ukraine, which also became a proxy war between the West and Russia (Katchanovski, 2022, 2023a, 2025b).

The dominant narrative promoted by the governments and the media in Ukraine and the West attributed the massacres of the Maidan protesters in both Kyiv and Khmelnytskyi to the Yanukovich government forces. (Boyd-Barrett, 2016; Katchanovski, 2024). The official investigation by the Prosecutor General Office of Ukraine (GPU) charged the Berkut police with the massacre of the Maidan protesters in Kyiv on February 20, 2014 on the orders of President Viktor Yanukovich and his heads of the Security Service of Ukraine and the Ministry of Internal Affairs. The GPU arrested and charged the Berkut special company commander and five

members of this police unit with the murder of 48 out of 49 killed Maidan protesters on February 20 on the Yanukovych order and with terrorism.

Similarly, the Ukrainian and Western media and the Ukrainian authorities attributed the killings and woundings of the Maidan protesters in Khmelnytskyi to the Security Service of Ukraine. The same special department of the Prosecutor General Office of Ukraine (GPU) that investigated the Maidan massacre in Kyiv charged in 2018 an SBU Alfa officer and then SBU Khmelnytskyi regional SBU head with killing an elderly female protester and wounding three other Maidan protesters in front of the SBU regional headquarters in Khmelnytskyi. Liudmyla Sheremet and Dmytro Pahor, two killed protesters in Khmelnytskyi, were included in the Heavenly Hundred of killed Maidan protesters. They were awarded posthumously Heroes of Ukraine titles by then President Petro Poroshenko, who was one of the Maidan leaders.

The New York Times, the Guardian, the Channel 4, PBS, and the Kyiv Post explicitly or implicitly attributed this shooting in Khmelnytskyi to the Yanukovych government forces.¹ Like in the case with the Maidan massacre trial verdict parts confirming the false-flag massacre, there was a blackout in the Western media of the Ukrainian court verdict concerning the shooting in Khmelnytskyi.

The Ukrainian media also misrepresented the Ukrainian courts verdicts concerning the Maidan massacre and the shooting of the Maidan protesters in Khmelnytskyi. The Ukrainian media for more than 12 years has blamed SBU officers for the killing and wounding of the protesters in Khmelnytskyi and omitted academic studies showing the false-flag shooting and the far-right involvement.

Similarly, Wikipedia misrepresented both the Maidan massacre and the shooting in Khmelnytskyi. Wikipedia states that Liudmyla Sheremet was “shot in the head by an SBU officer

on 19 February during the storming of SBU office in Khmelnytskyi.”² Its editors censored peer-reviewed academic studies, which showed that these cases of political violence were false flag operations with involvement of the far-right elements of the Maidan opposition. Wikipedia also censored verdicts of the Ukrainian trials concerning both these cases. (See Katchanovski, 2024, 2026).

The United Nations (UN) report, entitled “Accountability for Killings and Violent Deaths during the Maidan protests” also propagated the dominant narrative concerning the Maidan massacre and the shooting in Khmelnytskyi. The United Nations Human Rights Monitoring Mission in Ukraine did not conduct its own investigation of the Maidan massacre and the shooting in Khmelnytskyi, repeated in this report at face value the charges by the Prosecutor General Office of Ukraine, and omitted revelations about the false-flag shooting and the far-right involvement in both these cases. The UN report stated that “as a result of the shooting from inside the building by the SBU officer one protestor inside and three protestors outside the building received gunshot injuries, one of them died. In response to shooting, protestors blocked the building entrances and exits. Later that day, another protestor was shot and killed near the back entrance of the building.” (United Nations, 2021).

However, comprehensive scholarly studies of the Maidan massacre found that the far-right and oligarchic elements of the Maidan opposition, in particular the Right Sector and Svoboda, were involved in the Maidan massacre of the protesters and the police and that this was false-flag mass killing designed to falsely present is as perpetrated by the government forces. These studies were based on the analysis of primary evidence, such as videos, witness testimonies, testimonies of wounded Maidan protesters at the Maidan massacre trial and investigation, and forensic medical and ballistic examinations by government experts. (See

Katchanovski, 2016a, 2020, 2023a, 2023b, 2024, 2025).³ Their findings were replicated by Hahn (2018).

Similarly, these studies found that the elderly female Maidan protester was killed and several other Maidan protesters were wounded in Khmelnytskyi on February 19, 2014, in a false flag shooting with involvement of the far-right from the SBU porch that was then occupied by Maidan protesters. The analysis was based on the content analysis of the videos of the shooting and its investigation by the Ukraine's Military Prosecutor Office in Lviv. (See Katchanovski, 2021, 2023a, 2023b, 2024, 2025b; Video, 2018).

The content analysis of the videos of the shooting showed male Maidan activists breaking into a veranda of the Security Service of Ukraine (SBU) in Khmelnytskyi through a side window and then breaking its front glass doors from inside of the veranda. Sound of two distant gunshots was heard in the video with no protesters shot or other visible impact. And the Maidan protesters continued to break the glass doors from the inside of the SBU veranda. (See Video, 2018, 4:40-6:23).

Then some protesters apparently noticed a danger inside of the veranda and moved away to the sides, while another protester mimicked a Kalashnikov assault rifle being prepared for shooting. The video then shows a salvo of very loud multiple gunshots making bullet holes in a glass door in a direction of protesters and killing the elderly woman in the crowd of the Maidan protesters in front of the SBU headquarters. The zoomed video in slow motion shows gunshot flashes and gases and spent bullet casings flying in the air from that spot inside the veranda, which at that time was occupied by Maidan activists. The female Maidan protester with the deadly wound to the head is lying on the ground and another Maidan protester shows a gunshot wound in the stomach area right after this shot. (See Video, 2018, 4:40-6:23).

After this deadly shooting, the Maidan activists, the Maidan opposition, and the Ukrainian media immediately accused the SBU in perpetrating the killing and wounding of the Maidan protesters in Khmelnytskyi. The Maidan activists later on that day burned the SBU headquarters building in Khmelnytskyi and tried to storm it again.

The investigation and forensic ballistic examinations conducted by the Military Prosecutor Office in Western Ukraine after the Maidan determined that this elderly woman was killed and a number of protesters wounded by an unidentified Maidan activist from a machine gun from the inside of the veranda. Forensic ballistic examinations showed such bullet trajectories. The Military Prosecutor Office only investigated the accused SBU commander and other SBU officers and did not investigate the shooter and Maidan activists. The investigation “lost” bullets and bullet casings from this shooting and did not examine a link to disappearance of three machine guns of 7.62x54 caliber from the SBU headquarters in a neighboring Western Ukraine region during its seizure by far-right Maidan activists a day before. These investigation findings were not officially revealed but were reported by a ZIK TV channel. (See Katchanovski, 2023a, 2023b, 2024, 2025b).

However, the GPU reversed this investigation as politically inappropriate and charged an SBU Alfa officer for shooting the protesters in front of the SBU headquarters building from the second floor of the SBU building. It also charged the head of the SBU in the Khmelnytskyi Region with ordering this shooting. The Security Service of Ukraine publicly stated that the GPU investigation was falsified. But the SBU did not do anything to identify and prosecute those involved in the deadly shooting and falsification of the GPU investigation. Like the GPU and the police, the SBU after the Maidan came under control of the Maidan leaders and became a tool of

political persecution in Ukraine. Far-right Maidan activists, including open neo-Nazis, were integrated into the leadership of the SBU and the Ukrainian police. (Katchanovski, 2025b).

Similarly, Volodymyr Zelensky promised during the election campaign to investigate the Maidan massacre. But after his election as president of Ukraine in 2019, he abandoned this promise and turned the SBU into his secret police and the GPU in his prosecution tool. During the Russia-Ukraine war following the Russian invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022, he used the SBU and the GPU under his control to consolidate his undemocratic rule and persecute and arrest political opponents, rivals, and critics on trumped up charges. The SBU was also involved in torture, assassinations, and other extrajudicial killings, in particular, a killing of a Ukrainian negotiator at the Ukraine-Russia peace talks in 2022 and other major human rights abuses and criminal acts.

Like in cases of the Latin American and other pro-Western dictatorships during the Cold War, the Western governments and the media for geopolitical reasons denied, ignored or justified such undemocratic, illiberal, and illegal actions by the Maidan governments and Zelensky and their security, police, and other law enforcement agencies in Ukraine. Ukraine became a US client state after the Western-backed violent, undemocratic, and illegal overthrow of the Ukrainian government. Ukraine was also a Western proxy in the Russia-Ukraine war, which was not only a war between Russia and Ukraine but also a proxy war between the West and Russia and continuation of the civil war in Donbas. (See Katchanovski, 2025b).

In contrast, some studies attributed the Maidan massacre of the protesters to the Berkut anti-riot police or snipers from the Security Service of Ukraine and Internal Troops. (See, for example, Marples and Mills, 2014). However, they were not based on a comprehensive analysis of this case of political violence and uncritically accepted claims by the Maidan politicians and

the Ukrainian and Western media that the government snipers from SBU Alfa and Internal Troops Omega units and/or the special Berkut company perpetrated the massacre of the protesters on the Yanukovych orders.

The GPU investigation, the Maidan massacre trial, the Yanukovych state treason trial, and the media did not reveal any evidence of an order to massacre the Maidan protesters by President Viktor Yanukovych and his Internal Affairs, police, and SBU heads and commanders. The same concerns “titushki” hired by the Yanukovych government or any “third force.” The Prosecutor General of Ukraine and the head of its department in charge of the Maidan massacre investigation stated in the Ukrainian media that they did not find evidence of the involvement of Russian snipers in the massacre.

The absolute majority of wounded Maidan protesters testified at the Maidan massacre trial and investigation in Ukraine that they and other protesters were shot by snipers in Hotel Ukraina and other Maidan-controlled buildings. Nearly 100 prosecution and defense witnesses also testified about snipers in the Maidan-controlled locations. Original ballistic examinations of bullets by government forensic experts using an automatic IBIS bullet comparison system in 2015 did not match bullets extracted from the bodies of killed protesters to bullets from the Berkut Kalashnikovs. Forensic medical examinations by the government experts showed that nearly all Maidan protesters were shot from steep directions from the sides or back, which matched the Maidan-controlled buildings and did not match the Berkut police on the ground in front of the protesters. Government ballistic experts also determined in onsite investigative experiments that many protesters were shot from Hotel Ukraina, Bank Arkada, Zhovtnevyi Palace, and other Maidan-controlled buildings. (See Katchanovski, 2023a, 2023b, 2024, 2025a, 2025b).

The evidence of the cover-up included disappearance of the key evidence, such as security camera footage, many bullets, all shields and all but a couple of helmets of the Maidan protesters, and stonewalling of the investigations and trials by the Maidan governments and the far right, and denials by the prosecution that there were any snipers in the Maidan-controlled buildings

The nearly 1,000,000-word Maidan massacre trial verdict that was issued by the Sviatoshyn District Court in Kyiv in October 2023 following a seven-year long trial of 5 Berkut police officers confirmed findings of the studies by the author that many Maidan activists were killed and wounded and BBC and ARD TV journalists were shot at not by Berkut or other law enforcement but by snipers in the Hotel Ukraina and other Maidan-controlled locations. (See Katchanovski, 2024, 2025c; Vyroky, 2023; Maidan, 2023). It also confirmed findings of the studies by the author that this hotel was “activists-controlled” and that there was a far-right-linked special armed Maidan company in this hotel and the Music Conservatory. The verdict states there were no Russian snipers involved in the massacre and that there were no massacre orders by Yanukovych, his government, the SBU, and the Ministry of Internal Affairs. The trial verdict stated that Maidan then was not a peaceful protest but “a rebellion” which involved the massacre of the Berkut and other police members. (See Katchanovski, 2024, 2025c).

The verdict stated that “based, even only on the testimony of the victims themselves, there was enough data to make a categorical conclusion that on the morning of February 20, 2014, persons with weapons, from which the shots were fired, were in the premises of Hotel Ukraina.” The trial decision specified that 9 Maidan protesters were killed and 23 wounded by “unknown persons,” who were not “law enforcement officers” or that there is lack of evidence of

the involvement of the Berkut police, whose 5 members were charged for their massacre, in their killing or wounding. (See Katchanovski, 2024, 2025c; Maidan, 2023).

The trial decision explicitly stated that at least 6 specific protesters were killed, and many others wounded from the side of the Hotel Ukraina, the Music Conservatory, and from other Maidan-controlled locations and that this was “the territory that was not controlled by law enforcement agencies at that time.” This means that they were shot by the Maidan snipers shooting from these Maidan-controlled buildings since there were no evidence whatsoever that any snipers were located in between these buildings and the protesters, who were shot. And the verdict specified that Russian agents “did not have any participation” in the Maidan massacre. The judges and the jury explicitly stated in the trial verdict that during the massacre of the protesters the building of Hotel Ukraina was “controlled by the activists,” that these Maidan activists in the hotel were armed with hunting rifles and a Kalashnikov-like assault rifle, and that the Maidan activists shot from the hotel in targeted shooting, in particular, at the BBC TV crew, and that at least 3 Maidan activists were deliberately killed from Hotel Ukraina. (See Katchanovski, 2024, 2025c; Vyrok, 2023; Maidan, 2023).

The verdict also confirmed findings of the studies by the author that a former member of the Ukrainian parliament and far-right activist was filmed by a French TV in Hotel Ukraina as he “provides passage for activists” who are holding firearms that look like “a Kalashnikov assault rifle and a hunting rifle.” The verdict stated that a BBC video “captures the shelling from the side of the Ukraina Hotel building of the camera crew of BBC journalists (a single shot is heard)... and in the premises of the Ukraina Hotel, an activist is recorded with an apparent “pistol-type firearm.” The decision by the judges and the jury evaluated this BBC video “as documented data from the activist-controlled building of the Ukraina Hotel in Kyiv about the targeted use by the

activists of objects that, by their external features, are clearly similar to firearms, weapons of the type of hunting weapons.” (Katchanovski, 2024; 2025b; Maidan, 2023; Vyrok, 2023).

Such findings of the verdict are important not only for understanding this crucial case of political violence in Ukraine but also origins of subsequent conflicts in Ukraine, which culminated in the Russia-Ukraine war. They also corroborate previous studies by the author and show that the dominant narrative of the Maidan massacre propagated by the Ukrainian and Western governments and the media is false.

The verdict decision to convict in absentia three Berkut policemen, who were exchanged by Zelensky to Donbas separatists, for the murder of 31 protesters was politically motivated. It was based on a fabricated forensic examination of bullets, which reversed results of some 40 previous forensic examinations of bullets. This forensic examination also contradicted synchronized videos, forensic medical and ballistic examinations by government experts, and testimonies of the absolute majority of wounded Maidan protesters and several hundred witnesses, and the rule of law in Ukraine. (See Katchanovski, 2024, 2025c).

In contrast to the Maidan massacre trial which was streamed on YouTube, the trial of the SBU officers in Khmelnytskyi by the Khmelnytskyi court for the shooting of the Maidan protesters was closed and not streamed online. The text of the verdict, which was issued by the Khmelnytskyi court in March 2025 following this closed trial, was also initially classified. But it was subsequently declassified and is available on the official website of the court decisions in Ukraine. (See Vyrok, 2025). The next section examines revelations from this verdict and related investigations.

The Verdict and Investigations Revelations

The declassified text of the Ukrainian court verdict in March 2025 confirms the false flag shooting of Maidan activists in Khmelnytskyi during the Maidan massacre. Forensic expert examination of videos, forensic ballistic and medical examinations, on-site investigative experiments by government forensic experts, witness testimonies, and investigations by the SBU the Ukrainian Military Prosecutor Office showed that gunshots made from the SBU veranda, which was occupied by Maidan activists, killed elderly female Maidan protester and wounded other Maidan protesters. The verdict acquitted the ex-head of Khmelnytskyi SBU and the SBU Alfa officer for shooting of these Maidan activists because of the lack of evidence of their involvement in the shooting and because of such evidence of the false flag shooting.

The 2025 verdict publicly revealed for the first time that soon after the shooting in 2014 the special commission of the Security Service of Ukraine, which was then under control of the Maidan leaders, determined that “that the burst of shots from automatic weapons that rang out on February 19, 2014 at 12:36 p.m. and as a result of which some civilians who were near the administrative building were injured, was fired from the vestibule of the central entrance of the Department, where at that time unidentified individuals from among the aggressive protesters were located.” (Vyrok, 2025).

The verdict also revealed that a ballistic examination and the onsite investigative experiments conducted for the Military Prosecutor Office investigation in 2016 showed similar results:

Expert's conclusion based on the results of the ballistic examination of weapon traces, gunshot traces and situational circumstances of the shot under No. 5935/5936/16-33 dated 01.07.2016, from which it follows that: 1. According to the results of the investigative experiment dated 12.04.2016, 18.03.2016 and 25.02.2016, it can be

concluded that under the known circumstances and materials of the criminal proceedings, it was not possible to fire shots into the lower right static sash of the glass extension to the central entrance to the department, nor from the second floor of the administrative building, nor from the steps between the first and second floors of the Department. 2. The shots were fired from the middle of the glass extension of the central entrance of the Department of the Security Service of Ukraine in Khmelnytskyi region, outside. 3. The shots were fired from inside the glass extension of the central entrance of the Security Service of Ukraine in Khmelnytskyi region, to the outside; the weapon, at the time of the shots, was behind the back of the victim PERSON_131, at the level (or below) of the belt. (Vyrok, 2025).

The trial decision also noted the same finding of the forensic examination of the video of the shooting and experimental shots made from the SBU veranda. It referred to “an expert opinion based on the results of the forensic examination of the video recording dated 12.08.2016 No. 10358/10359/16-35, from which it follows that... “according to their general and individual acoustic parameters, the experimental shots fired in the hall of the second floor of the USBU administrative building in Khmelnytskyi region correspond to the shots of the first stage (and/or single shots) recorded in the studied video recordings” and “the experimental shots fired in the extension of the USBU administrative building in Khmelnytskyi region correspond to the shots of the second stage (out of eight shots) recorded in the studied video recordings.” (See Image 1; Video, 2018; Vyrok, 2025).

The verdict also revealed that other on-site “investigative experiments with the participation of PERSON_22 [the accused SBU Alfa officer] as a witness,” which were conducted by the previous pre-trial investigation body on 09.03.2016, also determined “that from the place where PERSON_22 was on the 2nd floor, it was not possible to fire shots at the lower part of the door of the central entrance of the office” and that it was “covered by an anti-vandal roller shutter.” (Vyrok, 2025). The court “found the information from the aforementioned investigative experiments and expert conclusions not refuted.” (Vyrok, 2025).



Image 1. The Khmelnytskyi court verdict & investigations by the Security Service of Ukraine (SBU) and the Military Prosecutor Office confirm that an elderly Maidan protester was killed and a number of protesters were wounded from the SBU veranda when it was occupied by Maidan activists. (Source: Video, 2018).

The verdict stated that the SBU in the Khmelnytsky Region received information about plan by the large radical group, which is term used in Ukraine to identify radical nationalists and neo-Nazis, to seize the SBU regional headquarters building:

On the morning of February 19, 2014, Colonel PERSON_21 was informed by the head of the USBU in the Ternopil region, Colonel PERSON_141, about the movement to the city of Khmelnytskyi of a group of radical individuals numbering about 80 people, whose goal was to organize the seizure of the USBU building in the Khmelnytskyi region and gain access to the storage areas of weapons and ammunition. This information was confirmed by the ZND department of the USBU, in addition, it was established that in the courtyards of residential buildings located near the administrative building of the

Department, radical individuals who arrived from the western regions of Ukraine were preparing for future active actions, in particular, filling glass bottles with an incendiary mixture. Taking into account the available information, the leadership of the USBU concluded that radically minded protesters were preparing to implement a planned scenario of seizing the building of the Department, as happened on February 18, 2014 in Lviv, Ivano-Frankivsk, and Ternopil regions. (Vyrok, 2025).

The trial verdict specifically stated that the SBU officer who was charged with the shooting of the Maidan protesters in Khmelnytskyi is not guilty because of the evidence that this shooting was done from the Maidan activists-occupied veranda of the SBU building. It noted that “under such circumstances, the defense's claim, with reference to the evidence presented, regarding the possibility of causing bodily harm to the victim on February 19, 2014, at 12:36 p.m., near the USBU in Khmelnytskyi region by interlopers [other persons] is not excluded, which in turn makes it impossible for the court to make a decision beyond reasonable doubt on the involvement and guilt of PERSON_22 in the charges brought.” (Vyrok, 2025).

The verdict also stated that there was evidence that Maidan activists used firearms:

The fact that during the commission of such actions the protesters may have used firearms and explosives follows: - from the information in the protocol of the initial inspection of the scene, regarding the termination of the investigative action due to the danger to the participants, in connection with the shots and explosions; - from the additional inspection protocol of 20.02.2014, submitted by the defense to the court, the conclusions of experts No. 79-B dated 13.05.2016 and No. 27-V dated 15.07.2014, regarding the discovery at the scene of the incident, in front of the central entrance to the department, of spent cartridges from 7.62mm pistol cartridges, as well as holes similar to bullets in the body of the trolleybus, which blocked the exit from the USBU from the side of Teatralna Street and in the garbage cans near the department fence. (Vyrok, 2025).

The verdict cites various eyewitnesses who testified that several Maidan activists broke into veranda (extension) of the SBU building, that gunshots at Maidan activists came from this

veranda when it was occupied by “radical,” i.e. far-right, Maidan activists and that the accused SBU officers did not make these gunshots. (Vyrok, 2025).

The accused Khmelnytskyi SBU head testified that he only ordered to fire some warning shots into a “safe place” when he was on the second floor of the SBU regional headquarters in order to prevent the seizure of the building and weapons there by radical Maidan activists from Galicia in Western Ukraine. He testified that some time after the warning shots were fired he heard a burst of gunfire and was told by SBU officers there that “it’s not ours, it’s from outside.” He said that the SBU officers then were armed only with AK-74 5.45 caliber assault rifles and with handguns. Their calibers did not match the caliber of the bullet core fragments from the body of the killed female protester and one of the wounded male protesters since their forensic examinations determined that these were most likely from a 7.62x54 caliber firearm and that hit an obstacle and fragmented before hitting these protesters as result of ricochet. (See Vyrok, 2025).

He specifically stated that the Maidan activists who tried to storm the SBU headquarters had incentives to do “a provocation,” i.e. shoot the Maidan protesters: “after the warning shots, those who were storming fell silent for a while and there was no point in the employees to do a salvo, but it was the opposite for those who were storming, in order to provoke.” (Vyrok, 2025).

The SBU Alfa officer, who was charged with the deadly shooting, provided a similar testimony about the warning shots from the Kalashnikov assault rifle of the 5.45mm caliber from the second floor and about hearing some time afterwards a salvo of 8 gunshots from the SBU veranda area which was then occupied by Maidan activists:

In fulfillment of such an order, PERSON_21 and PERSON_102 fired several single shots. He personally fired from an AKS-74 caliber 5.45 mm. first three single shots in a

row, and then approximately two more with short intervals. He fired such shots into a blind corner, the right column, from where the ricochet exit is not possible. He is sure that the bullets from the shots he fired did not hit the outside of the premises where the protesters were.... After such warning shots, there was no reaction from the protesters on the street, such as shouting. Those who were in the veranda fell silent for a while. Then, the chief PERSON_21 moved away from them with PERSON_101 in the direction of the duty officer's room and at that moment a long burst of approximately 8 shots rang out from behind the door, the roller shutters were intact. (Vyrok, 2025).

Their testimonies were supported by testimonies of several eyewitnesses and consistent with the content analysis of the video of the shooting and different sound volume of the two groups of shots. For example, the first deputy head of the SBU in the Khmelnytskyi Region at the time of the Maidan stated that “he heard that after the warning shots, there were shots fired in a burst, which he believed came from the veranda, while the warning shots were inside the headquarters building.” The head of the SBU Alfa unit in the region provided a similar testimony. Another SBU senior officer also stated that

He saw single warning shots, in particular, at the column. The warning shots were fired by both “Alfa” soldiers. PERSON_21 went to the guard, he followed him. Then he heard a burst of shots, which came either from the street or from the extension. At that moment, his back was to the “Alfa” soldiers. When he heard the burst of shots, he thought they were being shot at. PERSON_21 asked who was shooting. After that, from the guard’s room, they saw that someone was lying on the street and PERSON_21 gave the command to call an ambulance. He believes that the burst of shots was fired from the extension into the corner... (Vyrok, 2025).

The verdict also noted that the investigations did not determine that the bullet trajectories and the location of wounding of a Maidan activist [PERSON_17], who was filmed inside of the SBU veranda breaking glass doors during the shooting. He had four gunshot wounds in his right leg, but they were not consistent with his position in the video. The court decision also stated that two deformed grey bullet core fragments of 7.62x54 caliber from the killed and wounded

Maidan protesters “differ in appearance from the traumatic object that was removed from the limb of PERSON_17, but such an object was lost by the pre-trial investigation body.” The object “which has a flattened shape, is golden in color with brown spots, which was removed during the surgical intervention on February 21, 2014 from PERSON_17, according to the report of the inspection of the scene of the incident dated February 26, 2014, according to the prosecutor, was lost by the pre-trial investigation body, and no data on its examination was presented to the court.” (See Vyrok, 2025). This suggests a cover-up by the investigation.

The verdict states that the investigation after it was transferred to the same special department of Prosecutor General Office (GPU) that investigated the Maidan massacre “was not conducted fully and comprehensively, and was also obviously biased” and “committed a number of significant violations of the requirements of the Criminal Code, as well as the Criminal Procedure Code of Ukraine, which entailed the recognition of evidence as inadmissible.” (Vyrok, 2025).

The court decision also suggests that the GPU investigation falsified investigation data. It states that the court finds “unfounded and unconvincing, and therefore rejects and does not take into account” “the probable direction of flight and trajectory of the bullet” in the investigative experiment, which was conducted for the GPU investigation:

Since the information obtained during such an investigative experiment contradicts the conclusions of experts No. 5/781 dated 10/16/2014 and No. 8-5/496 dated 04/21/2017, according to which the bullet whose core caused the injury to the victim PERSON_16 after the shot was destroyed due to ricochet, i.e. collision with a solid object. However, according to the data established during such an investigative experiment, the possibility of ricochet is excluded, and the location of the shooter on the ceiling in the hall of the first floor of the headquarters building, where the laser pointer points at the end point, is obviously not possible. (Vyrok, 2025).

The verdict further dismissed conclusions of experts for the GPU investigation that all four protesters were shot by the same salvo from the inside of the SBU building. It stated that “such conclusions, in the opinion of the court, appear contradictory, since even with different trajectory of bullets due to the movement of the barrel during shots, taking into account the duration of the burst, such as 0.7 seconds, the movement of the shooter in the intervals between such shots is obviously impossible.” (Vyroky, 2025).

Nobody was charged for the murder of another Maidan activist and wounding of three others, who were shot in the head while the Khmelnytskyi SBU building was set on fire by far-right Maidan activists.⁴ The GPU investigation determined that a handgun bullet that killed him did not match Khmelnytskyi SBU handguns (Ukhvala, 2021). However, the far-right activists involvement in false-flag killings and woundings of the Maidan protesters in Khmelnytskyi was not investigated. This is consistent with cover-up.

Conclusion

The declassified Ukrainian court verdict and investigations confirm the false-flag killing and wounding of Maidan protesters in Khmelnytskyi with far-right involvement on February 19, 2014. The declassified text of the verdict, which was issued by the Khmelnytskyi court in March 2025 following a several-year long closed trial, and the Security Service of Ukraine (SBU) and Military Prosecutor Office investigations de facto confirmed, based on such evidence as videos, forensic ballistic and medical examinations, on-site investigative experiments, and witness testimonies, that an elderly female Maidan protester was killed and three others wounded not by the SBU officers from inside of the SBU headquarters but by a Maidan activist in the Maidan-

activist occupied SBU veranda during attempted storming by far-right Maidan activists of the Security Service of Ukraine headquarters in the Khmelnytskyi Region. This is consistent with the video content analysis showing that the protesters were shot from the SBU veranda and that it was occupied then by Maidan activists.

Similarly to the verdict and government investigation findings concerning the Maidan massacre in Kyiv on February 20, 2014, the Ukrainian trial verdict and Ukrainian government investigations also corroborate findings of previous scholarly studies of this shooting and the Maidan massacre in Ukraine. They show that the narratives propagated by the Ukrainian and Western governments and the media about these crucial and closely related cases of political violence in Ukraine were false.

The verdict by the Khmelnytskyi court also shows that the investigation by of the Khmelnytskyi shooting by the same special department of Prosecutor General Office (GPU) that investigated Maidan massacre was falsified and that the regional SBU commander and the SBU Alfa officer were false accused by the GPU for this deadly murder on trumped-up charges and that evidence against them was fabricated.

The determination by the Prosecutor General Office of Ukraine investigation That a handgun bullet that killed another Maidan activist did not match SBU handguns and the failure to charge anyone with his murder and wounding of other Maidan activist who were shot while Khmelnytskyi SBU building was set on fire by far-right activists suggest that this also was a false-flag shooting.

This verdict and investigations also confirm the cover-up by the Turchynov, Poroshenko, and Zelensky governments and the GPU and SBU of the false-flag shooting and Maidan activists and leaders, in particular, the far-right who were involved in the killings and wounding of

Maidan protesters in Khmelnytskyi. In spite of the verdict and investigations by the SBU and the Military Prosecutor in Ukraine confirming the false flag shooting of Maidan protesters, there was no investigation and prosecution of the actual shooters and organizers. Like in the case of the Maidan massacre, the investigation “lost” key evidence, such as a bullet which wounded one of the Maidan activists in Khmelnytskyi.

The declassified text of the verdict and SBU and Military Prosecutor Office investigations also highlight the role of the false-flag Maidan violence and the radical nationalist and neo-Nazi far-right in the origins of the violent conflicts in Ukraine and conflicts between Ukraine and Russia and the West and Russia, in particular, the Western-backed overthrow of the Yanukovich government, the Russian-annexation of Crimea, the civil war and Russian military interventions in Donbas, and ultimately the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war following the Russian invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022.

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Notes

¹ See <https://archive.nytimes.com/thelede.blogs.nytimes.com/2014/02/19/live-video-from-kiev-and-images-of-violence-in-other-ukrainian-cities/>;
<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2014/feb/20/ukraine-protests-spread-from-kiev>;
<https://www.pbs.org/newshour/show/news-wrap-kiev-truce-announced-bloody-battle>;
<https://www.channel4.com/news/video-shows-ukrainian-protester-being-gunned-down-ukraine-shooting>; <https://archive.kyivpost.com/article/content/ukraine-politics/public-outrage-spreads-to-regions-with-takeover-and-arson-of-government-buildings-reported-and-one-death-337165.html>

² https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Maidan_casualties

³ Some segments in the first part of this paper incorporate selected parts of Katchanovski (2024) and Ivan Katchanovski. (2024, February 20). Buried trial verdict confirms false-flag Maidan massacre in Ukraine. *Canadian Dimension*. <https://canadiandimension.com/articles/view/buried-trial-verdict-confirms-false-flag-maidan-massacre-in-ukraine-2024>

⁴ <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GNKQyS012kM>